discover that there was a highway connecting Xinjiang in China with Tibet, over the heights of Aksai Chin. As Aksai Chin was uninhabited except for nomadic yak herdsmen, the Chinese had been able to build the road without being detected.

But Tibet was another story. Civilians were butchered, and Buddhist monasteries and shrines destroyed. The repression that the Chinese unleashed in Tibet led to a revolt in the capital, Lhasa, in March 1959. It was crushed by the People's Liberation Army (PLA) of China, killing hundreds of monks and civilians, and sending tens of thousands of refugees to safety over the Himalayas to India. Among them was the spiritual head of the Tibetans, the 'god-king' Dalai Lama.

Before—and especially after—the Lhasa revolt, the Chinese had established military outposts all over Tibet, including in areas close to the Indian territory. New roads had also been built down to the Indian border opposite the NEFA in the east. It is not hard to arrive at the conclusion that China's own Forward Policy (although it was not called that) had been much more aggressive and assertive than India's.

Maxwell believes that the likeliest date of decision by the Chinese to attack seems to lie 'in mid-October 1962 because India has established an outpost at a place called Dhola, and escalated tension at the eastern sector of the border, which until then had been "dormant".'[5] According to some maps, Dhola is located north of the McMahon Line, the border between India and Tibet, on which the delegates from the British Indian and Tibetan governments had agreed upon at the meetings in Shimla in 1914. The reason why the Chinese representative only initialled and did not sign the agreement was because China did not recognize Tibet as an independent nation—an issue that has lingered since then and has prevented normalization of the situation along the border.

It is uncertain whether Maxwell is deliberately feigning ignorance of the Chinese build-up across and along the McMahon Line, which began shortly after the Lhasa revolt in 1959, or whether he is unaware of it. No serious military analyst could conclude that the decision to go to war with India on such a massive scale as occurred on 20 October 1962—or even the fighting that took place during the days before that—could have been taken only a week or even a couple of weeks before the PLA crossed the McMahon Line in the east as well as the LAC in Ladakh, 3,000 kilometres to the west.